carriers would be kept out of the "kill zone" of Chinese missiles and submarines in the case of any hostilities. However, with the loss of American lives, the White House ordered the Pentagon to send the *Gerald Ford* as a message to Beijing. This tactical decision would have strategic consequences in the coming weeks. It would take two days to get underway and seven days total for the *Gerald Ford* to reach the scene; in the meantime, only one US ship, the *Curtis Wilbur*, was in the waters of the accident, as the USS *Wasp*, an amphibious assault ship that carried ten US Marine Corps F-35s, was paying a port visit to Chennai, India, for a series of scheduled naval exercises with the Indian Navy.

US forces needed air protection, but with the *Gerald Ford* days away, the commander of US Indo-Pacific Command ordered US Pacific Air Forces to scramble four F-35As to the South China Sea from Kadena Air Force Base in Okinawa, a distance of approximately 920 nm (the F-22 Raptor's combat radius of 490 nm was deemed insufficient for the mission). The F-35s would then be deployed to Clark Air Base in the Philippines, to allow for longer-duration operations in the area. With a combat radius of 669 nm, the F-35 required refueling, and the mission was delayed until KC-46A tankers reached approximately halfway stationing points northwest of Luzon Island in the Philippines. After reaching the patrol station in the early afternoon of September 9, the F-35s encountered two PLAAF J-20 fighters launched from Fiery Cross Reef.[35] The Chinese radioed for backup, and two more J-20s soon arrived. After ten minutes of shadowing each other with repeated calls from each side for the other to withdraw, one of the Chinese jets attempted another close encounter head on, clipping the wing of one F-35. Both pilots were forced to eject, and almost simultaneously, a second J-20 launched an air-to-air missile at one of the remaining F-35s. At this point, the American pilots, who had received permission to defend themselves if fired upon, targeted and destroyed the three remaining J-20s, but not before one J-20 destroyed another F-35, with the loss of the American pilot. When the Chinese learned about the aerial encounter, the PLA chief of staff recommended missile attacks